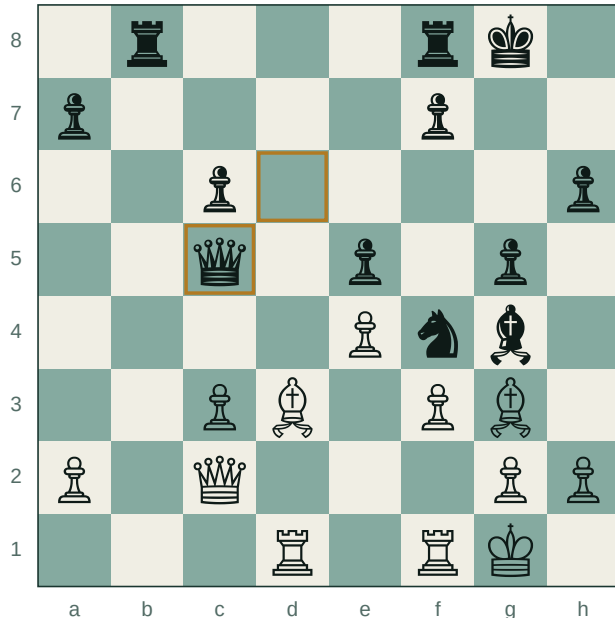


Active defensive resources: White, move 19

Active defensive resources

White to move



Previous move: 18...Qc5+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19. Bf2 Qa3 20. fxc4 Rb2 21. Qc1

19.Bf2 The bishop moves from g3 to f2. Recorded reply: **19...Qa3**.

20.fxc4 The pawn captures the bishop on g4. Recorded reply: **20...Rb2**.

21.Qc1 The queen moves from c2 to c1. From c1 it attacks rook on b2 and knight on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 31 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on c5 and bishop on g4. Check for tactical protection.